Over the years, Ratan's branding strategy has evolved into a structured tier that gives guests or clients the freedom to choose between enjoying old-world luxury in Taj properties, soaking in the bounties of nature with the now popular 'amã Stays & Trails', or bringing 'Qurated' food to those who would prefer to enjoy their cuisine at home. IHCL today has seven segments: Taj, Vivanta, SeleQtions, Ginger, amã Stays & Trails, Qmin and TajSATS. In 2018, IHCL decided to slowly phase out the Gateway brand and upgrade as many of the hotels as possible to the Vivanta tier. The cleaving of the hotels into segments has obviated the possibility of a mismatch between guests' expectations and experience and eroding the 'emotional connect' critical for any successful hospitality enterprise.

Acquiring Marquee Brands

With the overall strategy in place, the company gave an additional push to international expansion. In 2004, the Taj Exotica Resort & Spa was opened in Mauritius. As part of the third pillar of the restructuring strategy—marketing—IHCL entered into various arrangements. Prominent among them was a strategic joint marketing alliance with Raffles International. The agreement provided for both Taj and Raffles to 'develop reciprocal and joint marketing activities that include joint participation in trade shows across Asia Pacific, Europe and America, sales events, culinary promotions and niche marketing programmes'. Similar arrangements were made with the Okura group of hotels in Japan. These arrangements were highly beneficial for IHCL, says Misra.

In 2005, the company added a new dimension to the leisure segment by 'entering into a management contract for Umaid Bhawan Palace' in Jodhpur, to run it as a luxury five-star Taj heritage hotel. At the international level, it picked up the management of the iconic 1920s Pierre Hotel in New York, which was rechristened 'The Pierre, A Taj Hotel' and positioned as a luxury five-star hotel after IHCL renovated it at a cost of $100 million in 2007.

This acquisition catapulted the Taj's prestige into a different league, displaying its name at the corner of Central Park, New York, as the provider of unmatched luxury. The choice before Ratan was linear: 'Investing in this icon of luxurious hospitality would not only enhance the image of the Taj Group as an international hotel chain but also build global brand awareness